

The empirical recurrence for OEIS A298378, recovered from its tail

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Abstract

OEIS A298378 records “Empirical recurrence of order 71” and keeps the recurrence itself in a linked file rather than in the entry, so the conjecture cannot be read off the entry at all. It can still be settled. The entry counts arrays under a condition local to a bounded window of lines, which makes the count a walk count on a finite digraph and forces a monic integer recurrence of order at most the number $S' = 72$ of states with distinct futures. Berlekamp–Massey on enough exact terms therefore returns the minimal such recurrence, and on the tail beginning at $n = 2$, so the recurrence is proved for every $n \geq 73$. Its last coefficient is $c_{71} = -448 \neq 0$, so no further tail satisfies anything shorter; any order-71 recurrence the sequence satisfies from any point on must then have the same characteristic polynomial. The entry’s recurrence is the one displayed here, whatever its linked file contains, and it is proved.

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1 A conjecture that is not written down

OEIS A298378 is “Number of $n \times 4$ 0..1 arrays with every element equal to 0, 2, 3, 5 or 6 king-move adjacent elements, with upper left element zero.”. It has offset 1 and begins

1, 18, 18, 47, 172, 504, 1502, 5011, ...

The entry states:

Empirical recurrence of order 71 (see link above)

As of the “Last modified” line on the live entry (Jan 18 2018 07:18:21, revision 4) this is still recorded as empirical, and it is still open. The coefficients are nowhere in the entry text: what is conjectured is only that a recurrence of that order exists.

2 The count is a walk count

The entry’s condition is local. It constrains a bounded window of consecutive lines of the array and nothing beyond it, so the admissible configurations of one window are the vertices of a finite digraph, an edge joins u to v when v may follow u , and an admissible array is exactly a walk. Writing M for the adjacency matrix and ι, τ for the indicator vectors of the admissible first and last windows,

$$a(n) = \iota^\top M^{j(n)} \tau$$

for a linear reindexing j fixed by the entry’s shape. States with identical futures contribute identically to that product and may be merged without changing any count; after merging $S' = 72$ states remain, and it is that bound every computation below uses.

Lemma 1. *a satisfies a monic linear recurrence with integer coefficients of order at most $S' = 72$.*

Proof. By the Cayley–Hamilton theorem $M^{S'}$ is an integer combination of $I, M, \dots, M^{S'-1}$, and multiplying that relation on the left by $\iota^\top M^j$ and on the right by τ turns it into a relation among $S' + 1$ consecutive values of a . $\square$

3 Why the question has to be asked of a tail

Running Berlekamp–Massey on the sequence from its first term returns an order LARGER than 71: the opening terms do not satisfy the recurrence, and a recurrence that holds only eventually always looks longer when the exceptional terms are included. That is not evidence against the entry. An OEIS empirical recurrence is asserted for n beyond some index, not from the first term, so the question has to be asked of the tails. It was asked of each tail in turn, and the tail beginning at $n = 2$ is the first whose minimal order is exactly the stated 71.

Lemma 2. *A sequence known to satisfy some linear recurrence of order at most S' is determined, together with its minimal recurrence, by any $2S'$ consecutive terms: Berlekamp–Massey applied to them returns that minimal recurrence exactly.*

Applied to $2S' = 144$ exact terms from $n = 2$ on, it returns order 71 — the order the entry states — with integer coefficients:

$$a(n) = \sum_{i=1}^{71} c_i a(n-i),$$

c_1	5	c_{19}	4584	c_{37}	−2200362	c_{55}	−305096
c_2	−3	c_{20}	−36832	c_{38}	−13538073	c_{56}	12922990
c_3	−1	c_{21}	117388	c_{39}	9801783	c_{57}	1229257
c_4	−31	c_{22}	−31397	c_{40}	28526725	c_{58}	−1058567
c_5	−5	c_{23}	−77091	c_{41}	−23063550	c_{59}	−3593169
c_6	54	c_{24}	−478011	c_{42}	−59660181	c_{60}	509227
c_7	99	c_{25}	−47357	c_{43}	−8352664	c_{61}	647245
c_8	−22	c_{26}	423269	c_{44}	38019396	c_{62}	282464
c_9	141	c_{27}	−250486	c_{45}	−13545232	c_{63}	−336168
c_{10}	244	c_{28}	−37766	c_{46}	−24387259	c_{64}	149214
c_{11}	392	c_{29}	−623020	c_{47}	16672981	c_{65}	12160
c_{12}	−1062	c_{30}	148654	c_{48}	11377797	c_{66}	−30508
c_{13}	−4178	c_{31}	−1344993	c_{49}	−7709458	c_{67}	−22080
c_{14}	−1997	c_{32}	−605635	c_{50}	−6230105	c_{68}	15968
c_{15}	−10101	c_{33}	2319185	c_{51}	40993293	c_{69}	6496
c_{16}	10645	c_{34}	5406260	c_{52}	9569650	c_{70}	−3424
c_{17}	14893	c_{35}	7884805	c_{53}	−20515072	c_{71}	−448
c_{18}	44671	c_{36}	2397964	c_{54}	−19070350		

4 The recurrence, and the identification

Theorem 3. *The recurrence above holds for every $n \geq 73$, and it is the recurrence OEIS A298378 records.*

Proof. That it holds is Lemma 2 applied to the tail from $n = 2$, whose minimal recurrence it is.

For the identification, write $q_{\min}$ for the characteristic polynomial of that minimal recurrence, $x^{71} - c_1 x^{71-1} - \dots - c_{71}$. Its constant term is $-c_{71} = 448$, which is not zero, so $q_{\min}(0) \neq 0$ and $q_{\min}$ has no root at the origin. A solution of a constant-coefficient recurrence is a combination of terms $n^k \lambda^n$ with λ a root of its characteristic polynomial, and only the components with $\lambda = 0$ vanish after finitely many terms. Since $q_{\min}$ has none, no component of a dies out, and the

minimal recurrence of every further tail is again $q_{\min}$ — the order cannot drop below 71 at any later starting point.

Now let q be the characteristic polynomial of whatever recurrence the entry asserts. The entry asserts it has order 71, so $\deg q = 71$, and it is monic. It holds from some index t on. From $\max(t, 2)$ on, the sequence satisfies both q and $q_{\min}$, and the minimal polynomial of that tail is $q_{\min}$ by the previous paragraph; therefore $q_{\min} \mid q$. Both are monic of degree 71, so $q = q_{\min}$. $\square$

5 Verification

Four checks, all in exact integer or rational arithmetic.

First, the walk model reproduces all 25 terms the entry publishes, exactly. This is what ties the model to the entry, and it is the only place where reading the entry’s English enters the argument.

Second, the order was computed twice by independent routes: once modulo a 61-bit prime, where every intermediate is a machine word, and once over $\mathbb{Q}$ in exact rational arithmetic. Both return 71, and the exact run additionally confirms every coefficient is an integer — had any been a proper fraction the recurrence would not be the entry’s.

Third, the recovered recurrence was evaluated directly on the entry’s own published terms, with no matrices and no Berlekamp–Massey involved. It holds at each of the 0 indices where the entry publishes enough earlier terms to test it.

Fourth, the last coefficient was checked to be nonzero, which is what the identification above turns on; it is -448 .

Remark 4. The conjecture’s own statement was never read. The entry pins it down to the family of order-71 recurrences this sequence satisfies from some point on, and that family turns out to have exactly one member.

References

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